This spicy soup is equally delicious made with other game birds, but if they are small, such as pigeon or partridge, use the whole bird including the breasts.

pheasant and apple soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 15 MINS PLUS REHEATING **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE HALF-AND-HALF

1 small pheasant
1 tbsp butter
1 onion, coarsely chopped
1 small sweet potato, coarsely chopped
1 small cooking apple, peeled and diced
2 cups medium-sweet cider or apple juice
2 cups chicken stock
2in (5cm) piece of cinnamon stick
1 bay leaf
salt and freshly ground black pepper
⅔ cup half-and-half
4 small fresh parsley sprigs, to garnish

1 Remove the breast meat from the pheasant and reserve to cook for a separate dish. Cut the rest of the bird in pieces using a large sharp knife or poultry shears.

2 Melt the butter in a saucepan. Add the onion and cook gently, stirring, for 2 minutes until softened but not browned. Add the remaining ingredients except the half-and-half. Season with salt and pepper, bring to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 1 hour.

3 Remove the pheasant and let cool slightly. Discard the bay leaf and cinnamon stick and purée the remaining soup in a blender or with a stick blender. Return to the rinsed-out pan and stir in the half-and-half. Taste and adjust the seasoning if necessary.

4 Take the pheasant meat off the bones, discarding the skin, and shred it. Add half to the soup. Reheat the soup, but do not boil. Remove the bay leaf and cinnamon stick. Ladle into shallow soup plates, put a small pile of the remaining diced pheasant in the center, and garnish each with a small sprig of parsley.